

88 Inversion

Reversing the normal order of words, or inversion, can be used for emphasis or a sense of drama. It is common after certain types of adverbials.

See also:

Present simple 1 Types of verbs 49

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88.1 INVERSION AFTER NEGATIVE ADVERBIALS

In more formal or literary texts, inversion of a verb and its subject is used for emphasis after negative adverbial phrases like “not only,” “not since,” and “only when.”



In this simple sentence, the subject comes before the verb.

She is a famous singer. She is also a very good actor.

Not only is she a famous singer, **but** she's **also** a very good actor.

After the negative adverbial, the subject and the verb swap places.

“But” is optional.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

The auxiliary and subject swap places.

Not since my childhood **have I** enjoyed a performance so much.

Not until the performance was over **did he** look up at the audience.

Where there is no auxiliary verb, “do” is used.

Only if it stops raining **will the race** go ahead this afternoon.

Only when he emerged from the car **did the fans** start cheering.

Only after the race **did he** realize what he had achieved.

Little did they know how lucky they are to be successful.

Little did they realize how difficult fame would be.

